

India's eastern flank has emerged as a geostrategic hotspot in recent years. China-Bangladesh defence deals in fighter jets and drones and upgrades of ports and airfields, as well as Pakistani defence and intelligence presence in Bangladesh all point to it. In fact, talking about a conflict scenario, Pakistan's chief of defence forces, Gen. Asim Munir had stated in August 2025: "We will start from the east...." Now, Pakistan is hinting at tangible maritime moves at India's secure eastern seaboard.

In April, the first of eight Hangor-class diesel-electric submarines being built by China for the Pakistan Navy was commissioned. Last month, it completed its delivery voyage from China via Colombo and arrived in Karachi. During a naval event in Colombo, Commodore Omer Farooq, mission escort commander for PNS *Hangor*, stated that the new submarine would give Pakistan "the reach to maintain a presence in the Bay of Bengal". New Delhi took note of the comment—if realised, this would mark Pakistan's first naval presence in those waters since the 1971 war, when it lost its eastern maritime foothold.

BY PROJECTING SUBMARINES EASTWARD, PAKISTAN WOULD FORCE INDIA TO DEFEND BOTH ITS FLANKS SIMULTANEOUSLY. THE DANGER FOR INDIA IS A CHINA-PAKISTAN MARITIME FOOTPRINT IN THE BAY OF BENGAL

The waters of the Bay of Bengal, spanning approximately 2.6 million sq. km, remain central to India's maritime security. The region hosts India's Eastern Naval Command at Visakhapatnam and INS Varsha, India's highly classified nuclear submarine base. A Pakistani submarine presence could pose surveillance challenges to these installations. Major sea lines of communication linking India with Southeast Asia traverse these waters, making any Pakistani naval presence here a positive threat.

Naval observers note that the Hangor-class submarines—an export versions of China's Yuan-class submarines—could enable Pakistan to engage in covert operations in the northern Indian Ocean and the Bay of Bengal. Crucially, they are equipped with air-independent propulsion (AIP) systems, which allow non-nuclear submarines to remain submerged for as long as three weeks at a stretch.

Experts emphasise that, by projecting submarines eastward, Pakistan would force India to defend both western and eastern seaboards simultaneously. With China patrolling the waters of the Indian Ocean with increasing aggression, Pakistan's Chinese-origin submarine fleet could improve interoperability with the People's Liberation Army Navy (PLAN). Thus, for India, the greater concern is the emergence of a sustained Pakistan-China maritime footprint in the Bay of Bengal. In a conflict scenario, boats in the Bay could threaten merchant shipping and naval logistics, including routes to the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

Observers point out that Pakistani submarines have been confined to the North Arabian Sea since 1971, when PNS *Ghazi* deployed from Karachi to the Bay of Bengal, remaining on patrol off Visakhapatnam for several days before being sunk.

PAKISTAN'S NAVAL MUSCLE

Pakistan is pursuing an ambitious naval modernisation to counter India's maritime superiority and extend its reach. The programme includes new frigates, corvettes, long-range maritime patrol aircraft and cyber and space integration. The centrepiece remains the Chinese-made Hangor-class submarines. Pakistan has inducted the lead boat, PNS *Hangor*, with PNS/M *Shushuk*, PNS/M *Mangro* and PNS/M *Ghazi* to follow soon. These vessels feature AIP, as well as advanced